

Wolfram Eisenherz: The Penitent Baron

Physicality: At six feet tall and a solid 220 pounds of lean muscle, Wolfram is the very picture of a martial ideal. His black hair is kept short, practical for the helmet that so often covers it. Now 31 years of age, his face bears the stern, disciplined lines of a man who has known duty his entire life, yet his dark eyes hold a flicker of the idealism that has cost him everything. When prepared for battle, he is encased in a full suit of masterwork plate armor, intricately engraved with the old Eisenherz family crest—an iron heart clenched in a gauntlet.

The Weight of a Name

The name Eisenherz once commanded respect and authority across the vast Westfield region of the Western Diocese. For centuries, before the Cataclysm shattered the old world, Wolfram's ancestors were the sworn stewards of that land, their rule synonymous with justice and order. Now, the name is little more than a whisper of faded glory. The Cataclysm bled their lands, opening the door for bandit lords and twisted creatures to tear away at their domain parcel by parcel. While the common folk still regard the name with a measure of respect, the Eisenherz coffers are empty, their barony a patchwork of farms clinging fearfully to a fortified manor that has seen better days.

Wolfram's grandfather, the formidable Dietrich Eisenherz, refused to let their legacy die. A man of iron will and pragmatism, he scraped together the last of his family's wealth to hire a small company of mercenaries, appointing them as the first sheriffs of the new age. He rode with them, his aging armor a common sight on patrol, not just to fight but to ensure his coin was buying loyalty and not corruption.

This fragile shield of protection was just enough. Dietrich began collecting the old taxes, a pittance that did little more than pay the sheriffs' wages and repair their gear. He sought not to enrich his house, but to replant the seeds of civilization. His dream was for future generations to harvest the peace he was sowing.

The Father, The Son, and The Unholy Bargain

Dietrich's son, Konrad, was forged in his father's image—a dutiful warrior and leader. As Konrad took command of the sheriffs, Dietrich, seeing the limits of mere steel, turned his gaze to politics. The ascendant Empire of Azari was a distant power, but its church was not. Dietrich, though no man of faith, was a shrewd strategist. He saw the Church of Azeria as the tool he needed to bind Westfield together.

He journeyed to the Sunlit Citadel, the heart of the faith, and made an offer the clergy could not refuse: the Church could have land for a grand cathedral in Westfield, the service of the Eisenherz family in raising a congregation, and a tithe from the people. In return, the Church would provide its leadership and, more importantly, its protection.

It was a decade-long gambit, but it succeeded. The Cathedral of Saint Cuthbert the Vigilant, while modest by the Citadel's standards, became the grandest structure in the Western Diocese. Seasoned clergy arrived, and with them, a small battalion of the Church's holy warriors: the Penitents. The presence of the Church pacified the region more effectively than swords ever could. Westfield, while still untamed, was safer and more prosperous than it had been in living memory.

An Ideal Forged in Legend

Wolfram, Konrad's firstborn, was raised on two powerful tenets: duty to his people and respect for the Church that helped secure their safety. Though a member of the faith by birth, his true scripture was the history of his family. His fondest memories were of sitting at his grandfather Dietrich's knee, listening to epic tales from before the Cataclysm—of ancient Eisenherz barons who faced down dragons and defied demons. His hero was Friedrich Eisenherz, the Dragon-Slayer, a figure of pure, unwavering good.

As Wolfram grew, he understood these were likely just stories, embellished over centuries. Yet, the inspiration was real. He yearned to be that kind of champion, a bastion against the darkness. This fire drove him to train his body to the point of collapse and his mind to the point of exhaustion. He saw the Church as his grandfather did: a powerful force for order and good in the world, an institution worthy of service, even if he did not feel the gods' touch personally.

The Rot in the Cathedral

Everything changed a year ago. The beloved Senior Bishop of Westfield, Odo of Bayeux, retired after fifty years of compassionate service. His replacement from the Sunlit Citadel was a man named Thurstan of York.

Thurstan, a man in his forties with a deceptively average face, spoke of piety and discipline. But soon, the rot began to show. Church charities for the poor saw their funds cut, yet Thurstan's table was always laden with exotic foods and fine wine. He was dismissive and brief with the men of his congregation but would spend hours in private "counsel" with the younger women, especially the comely and impressionable.

Whispers turned to rumors: that Thurstan was using Church donations to seduce his flock, that confessions were being used for blackmail. When the town elders confronted him, he denied everything with cold fury. Soon after, the veteran Penitents who had served under Bishop Odo were reassigned, replaced by men whose only loyalty was to Thurstan. The elders who had spoken out suddenly found their farms unprotected, their requests for aid against bandits ignored. Fear, like a cancer, began to grow in the heart of Westfield.

An Act of Rage, A Lifetime of Penance

When the rumors reached Wolfram, his idealized world began to crack. He, who had sworn to protect these people, had allowed a wolf into the fold. Consumed by righteous anger, he strode to the cathedral, his hand resting on the pommel of his sword.

He was met by nervous junior bishops who claimed Thurstan was in prayer with a "troubled soul." Wolfram, sensing their deceit, pushed past them and threw open the doors to the Bishop's private chambers. The scene was worse than any rumor: Thurstan, his robes undone, with a terrified young woman barely out of her teens.

Thurstan's face contorted with rage, not shame. He bellowed accusations of heresy, even as the young woman sobbed that she had been forced. The argument escalated, Thurstan's voice dripping with contempt for the "provincial whelp" challenging him. In a flash of violence, Thurstan shoved Wolfram, sending him stumbling back into a heavy iron candelabra. The sharp metalwork gashed Wolfram's scalp open. As Wolfram reeled, Thurstan grabbed a heavy, gilded reliquary from his desk and struck him across the head.

But Thurstan was a soft-bodied priest. Wolfram was a warrior.

Training, instinct, and a lifetime of repressed fury took over. Between one heartbeat and the next, Wolfram recovered his footing, drew his ancestral blade, and slew the corrupt bishop where he stood.

The act was born of rage, and regretted in the instant it was complete. The sword clattered from his numb fingers. The righteous fury vanished, replaced by a cold, devastating horror. Whatever Thurstan was, it was not Wolfram's place to be his executioner. He had failed his ideals, his family, and his gods.

He fell to his knees as the junior bishops and Thurstan's Penitents burst into the room.

The Citadel's Judgment

The trial at the Sunlit Citadel was a farce. The young woman was never found—spirited away, they claimed, for "spiritual cleansing." The junior bishops told a practiced story of an unprovoked, heretical attack by the hot-headed son of a minor baron. It was Wolfram's word against the carefully constructed narrative of the Church.

He was found guilty. But to execute the son of a noble house that had gifted them their entire diocese would be politically foolish. Instead, they handed down a sentence of 500 years of service in the Penitents.

Wolfram was not to be a guardian of a cathedral, but an instrument of the Church's will in the darkest corners of the world. He was to be sent on impossible quests, to fight horrors

that would consume lesser men, to be a disposable blade pointed at the heart of their enemies. His armor is now his cell, his sentence a constant reminder of his single, defining failure. He is a tool to be used and broken, serving the very institution that betrayed his people and condemned him for trying to protect them.